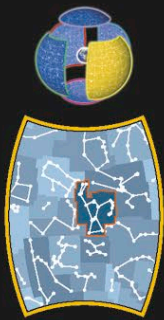


THE HUNTER

Orion



SIZE RANKING 26

BRIGHTEST STARS
Rigel (β) 0.2,
Betelgeuse (α) 0.5

GENITIVE Orionis

ABBREVIATION Ori

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
December–JanuaryFULLY VISIBLE
79°N–67°S

Orion is one of the most glorious constellations in the sky, representing a giant hunter or warrior followed by his dogs, Canis Major and Canis Minor (see panel, below). Its most distinctive feature is Orion's belt, formed by a line of three 2nd-magnitude stars almost exactly on the celestial equator. A complex of stars and nebulosity represents the sword that hangs from Orion's belt and contains the great star-forming region of M42, the Orion Nebula (p.241). In October each year, the Orionid meteors seem to radiate from a point near Orion's border with Gemini.



MULTIPLE COMPANIONS ✨

Sigma (σ) Orionis is a remarkable multiple star with three fainter companions—two on one side and an even fainter one on the opposite side—appearing similar to a planet orbited by moons.

MYTHS AND STORIES

THE GREAT HUNTER



In Greek mythology, Orion was a tall and handsome man and the son of Poseidon, god of the sea. The Greek poet Homer, in his *Odyssey*, described Orion as a great hunter who brandished a club of bronze. Despite his hunting prowess, Orion was killed by a mere scorpion, some say in retribution for his boastfulness. In the sky, Orion is placed opposite the constellation of Scorpius and, each night, the hunter flees below the horizon as the scorpion rises.

HUNTER AND WARRIOR

This depiction of Orion is from an ancient manuscript based on the *Book of Fixed Stars*, which was written by the Arabic astronomer al-Sufi around 964 CE.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Marking one shoulder of Orion is Betelgeuse—Alpha (α) Orionis (see p.256)—a red supergiant hundreds of times larger than the Sun. Betelgeuse varies irregularly in brightness between magnitudes 0.0 and 1.3, but it averages around magnitude 0.5. It is about 500 light-years away, and it is closer to Earth than any of the other bright stars in Orion.

Betelgeuse contrasts noticeably in color with Rigel—Beta (β) Orionis—an even more luminous blue supergiant, which marks one of Orion's feet. Apart from the rare times when Betelgeuse is at its maximum magnitude, Rigel is the brightest star in the constellation. Rigel lies 860 light-years from Earth—almost twice as far away as Betelgeuse. Its 7th-magnitude companion can be

picked out from its surrounding glare using a small telescope. Two other easily seen double stars are in Orion's belt. Delta (δ) Orionis has a 7th-magnitude companion, which is visible through a small telescope or binoculars. It is a greater challenge to reveal the close 4th-magnitude companion of Zeta (ζ) Orionis—this requires a telescope with an aperture of at least 3 in (75 mm).



BRIGHT HUNTER 👁

Orion, the hunter, is one of the most magnificent and easily recognizable constellations. A line of three stars makes up his belt, while an area of star clusters and nebulae forms his sword.